

Command words and mark allocation

1. What each command word demands

The command word is the instruction. It tells you how far to go and whether you need both sides. Mark allocations below are typical, not fixed, so always check the number in brackets.

Command word	What to do	Both sides?
Define / State / Identify	Give the meaning or name. One clear sentence, no explanation.	No
Calculate	Show the formula, the working and the answer with units or %.	No
Explain	Give a reason and say why, with a short chain of reasoning.	No
Analyse	Develop a full chain of reasoning, usually with a diagram, applied to the context.	No
Examine	Analyse in detail. Often "examine two factors": develop each in a chain.	No
Assess / Assess whether	Analyse both sides, then weigh them up and reach a judgement.	Yes
Discuss	Analyse arguments for and against, then conclude.	Yes
Evaluate	Analyse, then judge the importance, strength or likelihood of the points. A supported judgement is essential.	Yes
To what extent	Decide how far the statement is true and justify how far.	Yes
Justify	Give reasons that back a choice, and show why it is better than the alternatives.	Yes
Distinguish between	Explain how two things differ, using a feature of each.	n/a

Exam tip

"Assess whether", "discuss" and "evaluate" are the balance words. If you write only one side, you cap your evaluation marks however good the analysis is. "Whether" means: it is the case, or it is not the case.

For 8-mark questions the focus is analysis of one side. From 10 marks up, you need analysis and evaluation of both sides. See the [chain of reasoning](#) page for how to build the analysis.

2. Decode the question: four things to spot

Before you write, pull four things out of every long-answer question: the command term, the marks, the theory required and the context. Click through the three examples below to see the breakdown.

Example 1

Examine two factors that may cause changes in the price of coffee beans (Figure 2). [8]

Command term: Examine, and it says two factors. Develop two full chains.

Marks: 8. One-sided analysis, so no balance needed.

Theory: Supply and demand, and possibly price elasticity.

Context: Figure 2 and the international price of coffee beans. Use data from it.

Example 2

Assess whether profit maximisation is the main objective of the coffee shop owner (Extract A). [10]

Command term: Assess whether. Balance required: it is the case, or it is not.

Marks: 10. Analysis and evaluation of both sides.

Theory: Business objectives, profit maximisation ($MC = MR$), alternatives such as satisficing.

Context: Extract A and the owner's stated objectives. Quote them.

Example 3

Discuss methods the UK government could use to increase tax revenue (Extract C).
[12]

Command term: Discuss. Balance required: arguments for and against.

Marks: 12. Two or more developed methods, with evaluation and a judgement.

Theory: Methods of raising tax revenue, tax incidence, elasticity.

Context: Extract C and the UK government.

3. Mark allocation and time per question

Each paper is 2 hours for 100 marks, so budget about a minute per mark plus a little reading time. Use the marks to decide how much to write.

Marks	Approx. time	What the marks want
4 to 5	5 to 6 min	Short chain of reasoning or calculation, one diagram if asked
8	10 min	Two developed analysis points with application
10 to 12	12 to 15 min	Analysis of both sides, evaluation, a judgement
25	30 min	Plan for 5 minutes, then the six-paragraph essay structure

Do not write a 25-mark answer for an 8-mark question. Extra length does not earn extra marks and steals time from the essay.

Check the paper

The number of questions and their mark allocations differ by paper. Look at the front of a past paper for the exact layout before a mock.

4. Reading the case study and extracts

1. Read the question first, then read the extract with the question in mind.
2. Underline names, numbers and dates you can use as evidence.
3. Note which figures let you calculate or compare (percentage change, trends).
4. Put a quoted fact into the chain at the step where it fits. That is how the application marks are earned.
5. Use the extract in evaluation too: it often contains a hint about short run versus long run, or who is affected.

The extracts have most of what you need. A good answer keeps returning to them.